Liat Bar-Stav, an Israeli journalist, spent more than two months undercover with the group, and returned with a story of violence and racism. She recounted one incident in which Lehava activists were alerted to a group of Arabs talking with a Jewish girl in a public park.

> "Look at them running," one of the people with me says excitedly. "Wow! They're coming with brass knuckles and chains," adds another activist alongside me. My heart is pumping wildly, adrenaline rushes through me. Am I about to get involved in a fight just two hours after beginning my activity in Lehava? It turns out the girl isn't Jewish. Following a brief exchange of words, the two groups part ways; and I breathe a sigh of relief.[2]

While it sounds like a fringe group, it also has powerful backers in the right-wing government: Tzipi Hotevely, the deputy foreign minister, invited it to the Knesset in 2011 to discuss "procedures for preventing mixed marriages." Talk of a ban went nowhere. In 2016 Lehava proudly announced that it had completed its fifth annual summer camp, to train the next generation of ideologues.

Hilltop youth

The national-religious movement, as mentioned earlier, is divided between those who accept the legitimacy of the state and those who do not. The former is a much larger group. But, as the history of the Middle East amply demonstrates, it does not take many extremists to start a fire.

Some of them are known as the "Hilltop Youth," because they live in the most remote parts of the West Bank, in isolated settlements or in the "illegal outposts," the term for settlements built without approval from the Israeli government. Some outposts are little more than a ring of trailers, others rough dwellings inside of caves. Most of the activists are in their late teens and early twenties. They came of age during the *hitnat-kut*, the 2005 "disengagement" from Gaza. Prime Minister Ariel Sharon unilaterally decided to dismantle two dozen settlements in the strip and expel the 9,000 Israeli citizens living there. Four isolated settlements in the West Bank were also demolished. Polls at the time suggested that a plurality of Israelis, from 45 to 54 per cent, supported the decision. (They feel differently in hindsight: in 2015, on the tenth anniversary of the disengagement, 59 per cent of Israelis said they had opposed it.)

Over the past decade, Israeli security officials believe they have carried out hundreds of "price tag" attacks, burning homes and olive groves,